

30 places that *define* a journey through Nepal

From Kathmandu's living temple squares to the foot of the world's highest mountain — a field guide to the country's most-visited sites, with entrance fees for foreign visitors in both Nepali Rupees and US Dollars.

Reference rate — **US \$1 ≈ NPR 154** (July 2026, mid-market)

Prices shown are **foreigner entry rates** set by park & municipal authorities

Free = no fixed entrance fee at time of writing

Temples, Durbar Squares & the valley rim

Nepal's cultural core — three former royal cities packed into one bowl-shaped valley, ringed by hilltop viewpoints.

Kathmandu Durbar Square

01

The old royal palace complex of the Malla and Shah kings, with the Kumari Ghar (home of the Living Goddess), Hanuman Dhoka and Kasthamandap — the wooden pavilion said to have given Kathmandu its name.

UNESCO SITE

NPR 1,000 • ≈ \$7

Patan Durbar Square

02

Across the river in Lalitpur, Nepal's finest showcase of Newari stone and metal craft — the Krishna Mandir, the gilded Hiranya Varna Mahavihar, and a courtyard museum inside the old palace.

UNESCO SITE

NPR 1,000 • ≈ \$6.5

Bhaktapur Durbar Square

03

The best-preserved of the three medieval cities — pottery squares, the 55-Window Palace and Nyatapola, Nepal's tallest pagoda temple, rising five tiers above Taumadhi Square.

UNESCO SITE

NPR 1,800 • ≈ \$12

Swayambhunath

04

The hilltop "Monkey Temple" stupa overlooking the whole valley, its painted eyes watching in every direction — one of the oldest Buddhist sites on earth.

UNESCO SITE

NPR 200 • ≈ \$1.5

Boudhanath Stupa

05

The largest stupa in Nepal and heart of the Tibetan exile community — a slow clockwise walk beneath its all-seeing eyes at dusk, as butter lamps are lit around the base.

UNESCO SITE

NPR 400 • ≈ \$2.5

Pashupatinath Temple

06

Nepal's most sacred Hindu site, on the banks of the Bagmati River — a working cremation ghat, wandering sadhus, and pagoda-roofed shrines to Shiva. Non-Hindus view from across the river.

UNESCO SITE

NPR 1,000 • ≈ \$6.5

Changu Narayan Temple

07

A quiet hilltop temple east of Bhaktapur, the oldest Hindu temple in the valley still standing, ringed by some of Nepal's finest stone and wood carvings.

UNESCO SITE

NPR 300 • ≈ \$2

Nagarkot

08

A ridge-top village an hour from Kathmandu, famous for sunrise views stretching from Everest to Annapurna on a clear morning.

VIEWPOINT

Free

Chandragiri Hills

09

A cable car climbs from the valley floor to a ridge with a Himalayan panorama and a small Bhaleshwor Mahadev shrine at the top.

CABLE CAR

NPR 2,100 • ≈ \$14

Dakshinkali Temple

10

A forest shrine to the goddess Kali at the valley's southern edge, most vivid on Saturdays and Tuesdays when devotees bring animal offerings.

TEMPLE

Free



Lakeside calm and the trekker's gateway

Nepal's adventure capital, a lakeside city facing the Annapurna range — and the trailhead for its most-walked treks.

Phewa Lake

11

Pokhara's centrepiece — paddle a wooden boat out to the Tal Barahi island temple with the Annapurnas reflected on the water.

BOATING

NPR ~700/hr • ≈ \$4.5

World Peace Pagoda

12

A gleaming white stupa on a ridge above Phewa Lake, reached by boat and a forest climb, with one of Pokhara's best Annapurna views.

VIEWPOINT

Free

Sarangkot

13

The classic Pokhara sunrise viewpoint, and one of Nepal's best-known paragliding launch points above the lake.

VIEWPOINT

Free

International Mountain Museum

14

A Pokhara museum tracing Himalayan mountaineering history, indigenous mountain cultures, and the story of Everest's first ascent.

MUSEUM

NPR 1,000 • ≈ \$6.5

Davis Falls & Gupteshwor Cave

15

A waterfall that vanishes underground, feeding into a limestone cave with a Shiva shrine — a short, easy stop in central Pokhara.

NATURAL SITE

NPR ~100 • ≈ \$0.7

Annapurna Base Camp Trek

16

A 7–12 day trek through rhododendron forest and Gurung villages into a natural amphitheatre of 7,000m peaks — Nepal's most popular multi-day trek.

ACAP PERMIT

NPR 3,000 • ≈ \$20

Poon Hill

17

A short, popular trek to a 3,210m viewpoint above Ghorepani, famous for a sunrise panorama over Dhaulagiri and Annapurna South.

SAME ACAP PERMIT

Covered by #16

Mardi Himal Trek

18

A quieter alternative trek to a high ridge base camp beneath Machapuchare's fishtail summit, usually done in 4–6 days.

SAME ACAP PERMIT

Covered by #16



The trails that lead to the roof of the world

Reached by a mountain flight into Lukla or a long road approach — the highest, hardest, and most iconic trekking ground in Nepal.

Everest Base Camp Trek19

A 12–14 day classic through Sherpa villages, monasteries and suspension bridges to the foot of the world's highest mountain at 5,364m.

PARK + MUNICIPALITY

NPR ~5,000 • ≈ \$33

Namche Bazaar20

The Khumbu region's bustling trading hub and acclimatisation stop, built into a natural amphitheatre with the region's best gear shops and bakeries.

SAME PERMIT

Covered by #19

Gokyo Lakes21

A turquoise chain of glacial lakes and a quieter alternative route to base camp, with a Gokyo Ri climb rewarding a wide view of four 8,000m peaks.

SAME PERMIT

Covered by #19

Langtang Valley Trek22

A shorter, closer-to-Kathmandu alternative trek through Tamang villages and glacial valleys, rebuilt in the years since the 2015 earthquake.

LANGTANG NP PERMIT

NPR 3,000 • ≈ \$20

The lowland plains — jungle, rivers, and the Buddha's birthplace

South of the hills, a belt of subtropical jungle and river plain — Nepal's wildlife country, and its most sacred Buddhist pilgrimage site.

Chitwan National Park23

A UNESCO-listed jungle reserve reached from Sauraha — jeep and canoe safaris in search of one-horned rhinos, gharial crocodiles and, rarely, Bengal tigers.

UNESCO SITE

NPR 2,000 • ≈ \$13

Bardia National Park24

A far quieter, more remote jungle reserve in the far west — Nepal's best odds of a wild tiger sighting, with a fraction of Chitwan's crowds.

NATIONAL PARK

NPR 2,000 • ≈ \$13

Lumbini25

The birthplace of Siddhartha Gautama (the Buddha), marked by the sacred Maya Devi Temple, the Ashoka Pillar, and a sprawling garden of monasteries built by Buddhist nations worldwide.

UNESCO SITE

NPR 200 • ≈ \$1.5

Koshi Tappu Wildlife Reserve26

A wetland reserve on the Koshi River in the east, one of Nepal's best birdwatching sites and home to the country's only wild water buffalo herds.

WILDLIFE RESERVE

NPR 1,000 • ≈ \$6.5

Away from the headline sites — old trade towns, forgotten palaces, remote lakes and tea country.

Slower corners, off the main circuit

Bandipur

27

A car-free Newari trading town on a ridge between Kathmandu and Pokhara, its cobbled main street and old merchant houses largely untouched by modern development.

HERITAGE TOWN

Free

Gorkha Durbar

28

The hilltop palace-fortress of Prithvi Narayan Shah, founder of unified Nepal, reached by a steep stone stairway with wide valley views.

HISTORIC PALACE

NPR 100 • ≈ \$0.7

Rara Lake

29

Nepal's largest lake, deep in the remote far-west, ringed by pine forest inside Rara National Park — one of the country's least-visited natural wonders.

NATIONAL PARK

NPR 3,000 • ≈ \$20

Ilam Tea Gardens

30

Rolling tea estates in Nepal's far east near the Darjeeling border, with mist-covered hillsides and some of the country's best-regarded orthodox tea.

TEA ESTATE

Free

Note on prices — figures reflect standard 2026 foreigner entrance rates published by Nepal's national parks, conservation areas and municipal authorities. SAARC nationals and Nepali citizens pay lower or no fees at most sites. Multi-day and trekking permits are one-time entry fees, not daily charges. Government fees can change without notice — confirm current rates locally before travelling.

- Sources: Department of National Parks & Wildlife Conservation (DNPWC), National Trust for Nature Conservation (NTNC), Nepal Tourism Board, and municipal ticketing offices.
- Exchange rate used throughout: 1 USD ≈ NPR 154 (July 2026 mid-market rate) — rounded for readability.